pointed query. I was about to explain our poll methodology, when a rather shy, tentative-looking Rahul entered the room, and was promptly introduced by his mother.

We shared polite smiles. Slightly nervously, I began to show our data to mother and son. Mrs Gandhi seemed concerned, the son a trifle dismissive. ‘How can anyone do serious polling in a country of India’s size with such a small sample? I’ve done market research and know how difficult it can be to get these things right,’ was Rahul’s initial response. He struck me at first sight as someone who didn’t have too much time for pollsters or journalists. In fact, he almost deliberately demonstrated his scorn for urban election pundits in the usual fashion of a newly minted grass-roots embracer. As I attempted to defend my case, Rahul’s mobile rang. He excused himself and did not return. Mrs Gandhi remained attentive to our presentation. The contrast was striking.

The family picture was complete when Rahul filed his nomination for the 2004 elections. Son with mother and sister next to him and brother-in-law Robert Vadra just behind—the nomination ceremony in Amethi was a family affair. Watching it was an audience which, in Amethi at least, appeared umbilically tied to the family. We were attempting a ‘follow the leader’ programme, which essentially involved tracking a leader for twenty-four hours. It was a terribly hot April and the team’s energy was flagging badly in the heat. To make matters worse, the Special Protection Group (SPG) had created a firewall between Rahul and us. We spent four days in Amethi, seeking to speak and film with Rahul but with virtually no success.

Rahul just didn’t seem interested in speaking to us. We even chased him on a late-night walk with his brother-in-law, but to no avail. ‘Look, if I speak to you, I will have to speak to every news channel, and I don’t want to do that at this stage,’ was his firm response. When he finally did address the media in Amethi, it was almost as if he had been coerced into it. ‘I just want to take my father’s legacy forward and fulfil the work and dreams he had for Amethi,’ was his answer to most questions. Any slightly loaded political question was deflected. ‘I am not the leader of the Congress—you must ask Soniaji about this.’